ier than the structural economy. Capital expenditure has risen eightfold in a decade to Rs 26,409 crore in FY25. Debt-to-GSDP at 25.52 per cent is the 21st lowest among 28 states. Assam's own tax revenue has grown 75 per cent in four years to Rs 30,052 crore. But the dependence problem has not disappeared. Transfers from the Centre at 14.2 per cent of GSDP still fund 72 per cent of total revenue.

The harder economic challenge, though, is jobs. Sarma's first term provided more than 100,000 government jobs through transparent recruitment, a politically valuable achievement in a state where recruitment scams had corroded public trust. But government employment is limited. Sarma has to create conditions for private sector employment, skilled work, services, manufacturing and self-employment to grow at scale. While big industries will create jobs—for instance, the Tata Semiconductor facility in Morigaon district is expected to generate 15,000 direct and 11,000-13,000 indirect jobs—the immediate priority for the government, given the state's economic context, should be to aggressively promote self-employment.

"While highways, bridges and urban expansion have transformed the state's visual landscape, the real test lies in creating jobs for educated youth and building an economy that moves beyond construction-driven growth," says Professor Gogoi. Sarma appears to recognise this: through a series of social media posts before taking oath, he outlined a jobs agenda centred on MSMEs, entrepreneurship and self-employment, promising Rs 5 lakh in entrepreneurship support for 1 million youths and a sharper focus on startups, local economic growth, employment and industrial expansion.

FIVE KEY CHALLENGES

1. **Ensuring decisive governance does not slide into centralisation, complacency or intolerance of dissent**
2. **Acting against illegal immigration without alienating or targeting lawful Indian Muslims**
3. **Translating high growth into higher incomes, industrial expansion and stronger revenues**
4. **Creating large-scale private sector, MSME and skilled job opportunities**
5. **Building a development model rooted in inclusion, human capital and sustainable growth**



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IN SEARCH OF A MODEL

The past five years were the foundation-laying stage of what Sarma calls the Himanta Biswa Sarma model. So far, the model has three visible parts: infrastructure development, welfare expansion and efficient governance. The governance component includes land reforms, faster service delivery, transparent recruitment and a stronger law-and-order image. The agenda for the second term should build on that progress, but the larger objective has to be growth that creates employment. The economic agenda has a national audience, too. Sarma represents Assam, a state with 14 Lok Sabha seats that still trails the national average on most economic indicators.

That is why he needs more than combativeness. Nationally, Sarma is known as much for his sharp, often polarising statements as for his administrative energy. But rabid rhetoric alone cannot build a national claim. Even Prime Minister Narendra Modi's rise from Gujarat was never based only on Hindutva. He paired ideological consolidation with a development story that travelled beyond Gujarat. Sarma will have to build an Assam model that is recognisably economic in the same way, and inclusive enough not to collapse under its own communal arithmetic.

The inclusiveness already exists in Sarma's governance. His welfare schemes have made no distinction between Hindus and Muslims. The challenge, however, for the second term is that the same inclusiveness needs to reflect in his political actions and language, too. ■